

Course Overview: The Eight-Hour Entrepreneur

The **Eight-Hour Entrepreneur** is an intensive, virtual "learning lab" designed to take early-stage entrepreneurs from an unrefined concept to a validated, launch-ready venture in **8 total hours** (four 2-hour virtual sessions).

Rather than running as a traditional 2-day CO.STARTERS Bootcamp, this virtual adaptation uses 7-day gaps between weekly sessions as "**Field Discovery Windows**". These intervals force participants out of the "idea trap" to test assumptions against real-world customer friction, operationalizing the core philosophy: **Clarity** → **Validation** → **Action** → **Launch**.

Structure & Delivery Format

- **Total Duration:** 4 weeks, 1 session per week, 2 hours per session (8 hours total).
- **Delivery:** Virtual live cohort using video conferencing (with breakout rooms), collaborative digital canvas whiteboards (Google Slides), and an asynchronous community hub (Slack group provided by MTN.org).
- **Framework:** Centered around all 11 building blocks of the **CO.STARTERS Canvas** (*Customer, Problem, Solution, Alternatives, Benefit, Advantage, Message, Distribution, Revenue, Startup Needs, Costs*).

Week-by-Week Syllabus

Week 1: From Idea → Real Opportunity (Discover)

- **Theme:** *"Is this actually a business?"*
- **Canvas Blocks Covered:** Customer, Problem, Solution.
- **Agenda Breakdown:**
 - **0:00–0:20 | Welcome + Founder Stories:** Introductions ("What are you trying to build?") and establishing psychological safety by normalizing messy, unpolished ideas.
 - **0:20–1:00 / 1:20 | Canvas Sprint (Part 1):** Rapid-fire mapping of Customer, Problem, and initial Solution (utilizing breakout pairs).
 - **1:00 / 1:20–1:40 / 1:45 | Reality Check Exercise (The Pressure Test):** Probing who actually feels the pain point, when they felt it last, and whether solving it takes priority over essential bills.
 - **1:40 / 1:45–2:00 | Homework / Discovery Sprint:** Schedule and conduct discovery interviews with **3 real people** before Session 2 (asking questions, not selling).
- **Outputs:** Draft business idea, defined target customer, and 3 customer conversations scheduled.

Week 2: Validate Before You Build

- **Theme:** *"Don't build what nobody wants"*
- **Canvas Blocks Covered:** Alternatives, Benefit, Advantage.

- **Agenda Breakdown:**
 - **0:00–0:30 | Debrief Customer Conversations:** Analyze findings from interviews, identify surprises, dismantle weak assumptions, and "kill" or pivot invalid concepts.
 - **0:30–1:15 | Canvas Sprint (Part 2):** Map existing competition/workarounds (Alternatives), why the solution matters (Benefit), and the founder's unique edge (Advantage).
 - **1:15–1:40 | Starting Small (Lean Test):** Define the smallest testable iteration—focusing on *service before product*, *manual before automated*, and *pre-selling before building*.
 - **1:40–2:00 | Homework / The Validation Test:** Execute one real-world lean test (e.g., manual service delivery, pre-sale offer, or direct post).
- **Outputs:** Refined concept grounded in real feedback, definition of a minimum testable version, and an active validation test.

Week 3: Make It Real (Money + Messaging)

- **Theme:** *"How does this actually become a business?"*
- **Canvas Blocks Covered:** Message, Distribution, Revenue, Startup Needs, Costs.
- **Agenda Breakdown:**
 - **0:00–0:30 | Test Results Debrief:** Evaluate the lean test ("Did anyone say yes? Did anyone pay? Why or why not?").
 - **0:30–1:10 / 1:15 | Build Your Offer & Financials:** Define what is being sold, pricing models, distribution channels, and map out one-time **Startup Needs** vs. ongoing **Costs**.
 - **1:10 / 1:15–1:45 | Messaging Workshop:** Craft a clear, 1-sentence value proposition and draft high-conversion social/media copy simple enough for an outsider to grasp in 5 seconds.
 - **1:45–2:00 | Homework:** Practice the messaging and sales approach live with at least one prospective customer.
- **Outputs:** Clear offer structure, validated pricing direction, baseline cost structure, and a concise messaging statement.

Week 4: Launch Plan + Momentum

- **Theme:** *"Now go do it"*
- **Canvas Blocks Covered:** Synthesis of full Canvas into an actionable roadmap.
- **Agenda Breakdown:**
 - **0:00–0:45 | Wins + Lessons:** Review progress, normalize setbacks, and celebrate time/money-saving pivots as direct wins.
 - **0:45–1:30 | 30-Day Launch Plan:** Build a concrete operational roadmap covering:
 - 1. *What* to sell
 - 2. *Who* to sell to

3. *How* to reach them
 4. *Weekly targets* for the upcoming 30 days
- **1:30–2:00 | Mini Pitch + Commitments:** 2-minute pitch per founder, peer feedback, public commitment to 30-day goals, and handoff to continuing platform ecosystems (coaching, slack group, etc.)
 - **Outputs:** 30-day action plan, defined weekly milestones, peer accountability network, and pitch readiness.

Core Participant Takeaways

- **Validated Thinking:** Moves founders away from unverified assumptions into evidence-based decision-making.
- **Lean Execution:** Emphasizes simple, manual, low-capital methods to generate revenue immediately.
- **Clear Articulation:** Distills complex, messy visions into crisp, 1-sentence value propositions and direct offers.
- **Actionable Next Steps:** Replaces multi-year theoretical business plans with an immediate, milestone-driven 30-day launch roadmap backed by peer accountability.